

Q Do I have to forego high heels completely?

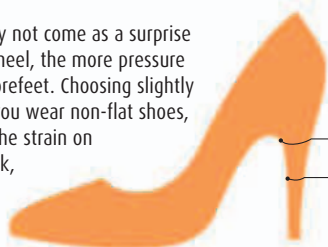
There's no edict banning high heels in pregnancy, but most podiatrists advise against them once your belly starts to grow, so save them for special occasions.

High heels change your posture, increasing the strain on your knees and encouraging you to arch your back to compensate for the change in weight distribution. This effect is exacerbated in pregnancy due to your softened joints and ligaments (caused by the hormone relaxin) and your changing center of gravity, so wear high heels only occasionally to prevent aches and pains.

Comfort and support

During pregnancy, you will find low-heeled, wide-fitting, supportive shoes that preserve your foot arch much more comfortable for everyday wear. It's common for feet to swell in pregnancy, caused by extra fluids in the body (known as edema). Some women even find that their feet go up a half or whole size, again due to relaxin causing the ligaments in the feet to spread. Choose shoes with a slight, firm heel of 1 in (2.5 cm), to discourage you from leaning backward. Beware of completely flat shoes since they offer little in the way of cushioning and comfort as your weight increases.

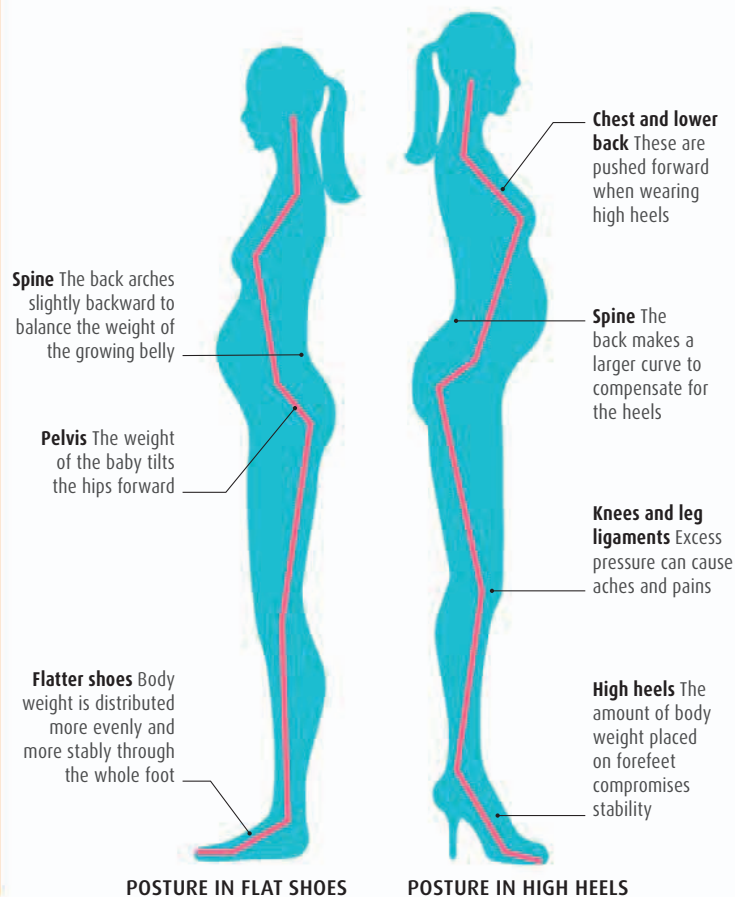
Higher heels It may not come as a surprise that the higher the heel, the more pressure you place on your forefeet. Choosing slightly lower heels, when you wear non-flat shoes, can help to reduce the strain on your feet, lower back, and knees.



3 in (7.5 cm) high:
76% pressure
2 in (5 cm) high:
57% pressure

WEARING HEELS IN PREGNANCY

When you're pregnant, wearing high heels is more of a balancing act than usual. Your growing belly throws your weight forward, forcing you to adjust your spine, knees, and leg alignment to maintain your balance.



POSTURE IN FLAT SHOES

POSTURE IN HIGH HEELS

Q Should I buy a special maternity swimsuit, or make do?

This depends on how much swimming you plan to do during pregnancy. If you want to swim regularly—swimming is a perfect pregnancy exercise, after all—it's worth investing in a pregnancy swimsuit specially designed to support your growing belly and bust and adapt with your changing body, while also providing comfort and ease of movement. However, if all you need a swimsuit for is a two-week vacation in the sun, then you may be able to get away with an existing stretchy swimsuit, or a bikini or tankini that fits under and over your belly.

Pregnancy swimsuits If you are swimming regularly for exercise, a supportive maternity swimsuit is a worthwhile investment.



Q I will be heavily pregnant in the winter. Will I need to buy a maternity coat?

If you want to invest in a special maternity coat, by all means do so, but you may find that a winter coat will make you feel uncomfortably warm, even if the weather is cold. Before you shop for extra layers of maternity clothing, keep in mind that your natural body temperature will be higher toward the end of your pregnancy as your blood circulation increases. A maternity coat may not be necessary, and since a coat is quite a large investment, you may prefer to keep warm by wearing knit layers instead. You could put on a lighter waterproof raincoat, shawl, fleece, or scarf over these knit items so that you can remove one or more layers if you do get hot.